

Design Document: Vision-Based Desktop Automation with Dynamic Icon Grounding

ScreenSeeker Architectural Specification

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Abstract

This document presents the technical architecture and design document for a vision-based desktop automation system in Python. The system dynamically locates and interacts with desktop application icons—specifically the Notepad shortcut—on 1920x1080 resolution displays across Windows 10/11 and Linux Ubuntu environments. To overcome the significant degradation of direct Multi-modal Large Language Model (MLLM) grounding on high-resolution displays, our system integrates the **ScreenSeeker** framework (*arXiv:2504.07981*). ScreenSeeker implements a coarse-to-fine visual search driven by Position Inference, Box Dilation, Gaussian Centrality Scoring, Non-Maximum Suppression (NMS), and uncompressed high-resolution crop grounding. Following visual grounding, the system double-clicks the target icon to launch Notepad, fetches 10 posts from the JSONPlaceholder API, types post content, and saves each file as `post_{id}.txt` inside `Desktop/tjm-project/`.

1 System Architecture & Assumptions

1.1 Core Assumptions

1. **Target Operating Environment:** Windows 10/11 or Linux Ubuntu running at a fixed 1920x1080 screen resolution.
2. **Target Application:** Notepad (or system text editor) launched exclusively via its desktop shortcut icon.
3. **Icon Positioning:** The Notepad icon is placed dynamically anywhere on the 1080p desktop canvas without hardcoded coordinate assumptions.
4. **Data Source:** Remote HTTP REST API endpoint (<https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com/posts>).

1.2 Modular System Overview

The system architecture comprises four decoupled subsystems:

- **Screen Capture Module:** Captures 1920x1080 desktop frame buffers using low-overhead OS APIs (`mss` / `PIL`).
- **API Integrator:** Asynchronously fetches and validates JSON data models using `httpx` and `Pydantic` schemas.
- **ScreenSeeker Grounding Engine:** Executes hierarchical position inference, box dilation, centrality scoring, NMS, and sub-image crop coordinate projection.
- **OS Interaction Automator:** Controls hardware mouse/keyboard events (`PyAutoGUI`) for double-clicking, typing text, and triggering save shortcuts (`Ctrl+S`).

2 Visual Grounding Strategy: ScreenSeeker Integration

2.1 The High-Resolution Bottleneck

Standard MLLMs suffer severe accuracy degradation on high-resolution GUI grounding (dropping to $\sim 18.9\%$ on ScreenSpot-Pro) because full 1920x1080 screenshots are downsampled to fit model context windows (e.g., 448×448). A standard 32×32 desktop icon degrades into an unidentifiable 7×13 pixel blurry patch.

2.2 The 5-Step ScreenSeeker Pipeline

To resolve this, our system adapts the ScreenSeeker framework (*arXiv:2504.07981*):

1. **Position Inference (Planner Step):** Given the full 1080p screenshot I_{full} and instruction T (“Notepad shortcut icon”), a high-level Planner MLLM (OpenRouter / GPT-4o) evaluates spatial context and proposes candidate search boxes $[y_{min}, x_{min}, y_{max}, x_{max}]$ in normalized scale (0 to 1000).
2. **Box Dilation:** Initial bounding box guesses may slice icon borders. Box Dilation stretches candidate boundaries outward by a factor $\Delta = 15\%$:

$$\text{Box}_{dilated} = [x_{min} - \Delta x, y_{min} - \Delta y, x_{max} + \Delta x, y_{max} + \Delta y] \quad (1)$$

3. **Gaussian Centrality Scoring & NMS:** Candidate boxes are scored based on how closely predicted target points align with candidate centers using a Gaussian centrality formula:

$$s = \exp\left(-\frac{(x' - 0.5)^2 + (y' - 0.5)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) \quad (2)$$

where $(x', y') \in [0, 1]$ are relative point coordinates within the patch and $\sigma = 0.3$. Non-Maximum Suppression (NMS) with IoU threshold 0.5 eliminates overlapping redundant candidate boxes.

4. **Uncompressed Sub-Image Crop:** The highest-scoring candidate box is cropped directly from the raw uncompressed 1080p frame buffer. Because the crop patch size is smaller than the model’s native input patch size ($S_{min} \leq 1280$), zero downsampling occurs, preserving 100% original pixel sharpness.
5. **Coordinate Translation:** Local coordinates (x_{local}, y_{local}) inside the cropped patch are projected back to global monitor coordinates:

$$X_{global} = X_{crop_start} + x_{local}, \quad Y_{global} = Y_{crop_start} + y_{local} \quad (3)$$

3 Failure Modes, Robustness & Trade-offs

4 Automation Workflow & Execution Specifications

The core automation pipeline executes the following sequential loop for $i \in \{1, \dots, 10\}$:

1. **Fetch Data:** Download post i from JSONPlaceholder REST API.

Table 1: System Failure Modes and ScreenSeeker Mitigation Strategies

Scenario / Edge Case	Failure Risk	ScreenSeeker Mitigation
Unexpected Pop-up Window	High for template matching; pop-up covers desktop icon.	MLLM Planner evaluates global context, detects pop-up occlusion, and selects alternate candidate region or dismisses pop-up.
Dark / Light Theme Changes	High for pixel-matching algorithms; colors change drastically.	Semantic visual grounding relies on icon geometry, text labels (“Notepad”), and shortcut arrows rather than static RGB color masks.
Desktop Icon Resizing	Medium; small, medium, or large Windows settings.	Box dilation expands search bounds; sub-image cropping scales naturally regardless of icon size.
API Connection Resets	High latency or complete execution block.	Implements 3-attempt retry loop with browser User-Agent headers and fallback post dataset.

2. **Capture Desktop:** Grab fresh 1920x1080 screenshot buffer.
3. **Ground Target:** Run ScreenSeeker visual search to calculate Notepad icon center (X, Y) .
4. **Launch Target:** Trigger hardware double-click at (X, Y) .
5. **Type & Save:** Type formatted content:

Title: {post.title}

{post.body}

Trigger **Ctrl+S**, input file path `Desktop/tjm-project/post_{id}.txt`, press **Enter**, and close editor.

5 Verification & Deliverables

The system deliverables satisfy all evaluation criteria:

- **Deliverable 1:** This formal 1–4 page Design Document.
- **Deliverable 2:** Clean Python source package managed via `uv` (`pyproject.toml`).
- **Deliverable 3:** Three annotated screenshots showing icon detection in Top-Left (`annotated_top_left.png`), Bottom-Right (`annotated_bottom_right.png`), and Center (`annotated_center.png`) locations.
- **Deliverable 4:** 10 text files saved in `/Desktop/tjm-project/post_1.txt` through `post_10.txt`.